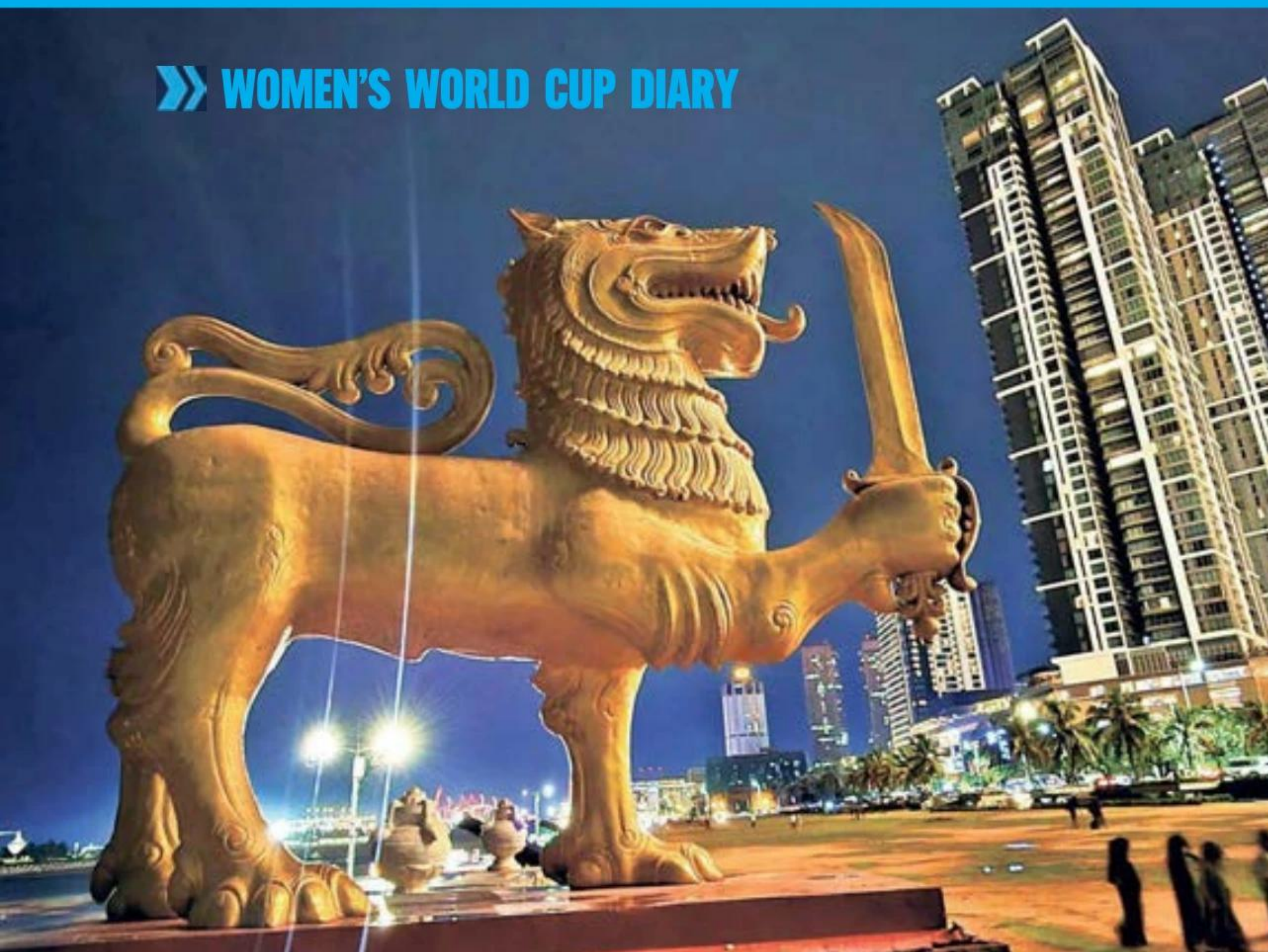




Much-needed break: A moment of calm by the sea — Galle Face after the rains, where the Diary traded deadlines for sea breeze and quiet reflection. LAVANYA LAKSHMI NARAYANAN

Stadium symphony: From Tamil beats to Sinhala hits, the stands swayed in unison as Colombo found its festive rhythm under the floodlights. LAVANYA LAKSHMI NARAYANAN

Between overs and oceans

On the road with cricket's **grand carnival** — our team brings you scenes from across the Women's World Cup.

Cricket-loving locals in Sri Lanka found themselves in a mild dilemma as the Women's World Cup made its debut on Lankan soil. With every match scheduled at Colombo's R. Premadasa Stadium, opinions were split — delight at seeing a 'major' venue added to the roster, unlike India's tier-2 picks, mixed with unease about how a 40,000-seater would look if the crowds stayed away.

"Dambulla or Pallekele are better venues for women's cricket. The Asia Cup, which Sri Lanka won last year, drew great crowds in Dambulla. But Colombo is the logistically convenient option for a multi-team event," said

local reporters during the Pakistan-Bangladesh game, played before sparse stands.

Glitchy promotions weren't the Diary's only worry. A motherboard failure in its work laptop sparked panic on the eve of the India-Pakistan clash — a crisis conveniently averted when rain washed out play, offering time to hunt down a fix. The downpour also cooled Colombo enough for an evening escape to Galle Face, where a coffee-less cold coffee and a quick lesson in Dutch history proved unexpectedly restorative.

At the India-Pakistan game, experience depended on one's seat. While 'gesture-watch' animated the

press box, the stands offered unfiltered joy — neutral fans dancing to Tamil, Hindi, and Sinhala tunes, joined by academy kids and expats. A mid-innings Emirates cabin-crew performance drew laughter and applause. For once, the noise around cricket was just that — noise, not controversy.

Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan

Festive lights, heavy hearts

The emotions were mixed ahead of the World Cup's opening match in Guwahati. There was the excitement of hosting the biggest event in women's cricket, and the city was alive with Durga Puja celebrations. Yet, beneath the festive mood lay a